CHAPTER 16

Gender Budgeting Practices in Sub-Saharan Africa

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In the context of constrained fiscal space and exacerbated gender inequalities resulting from the COVID-19 pandemic, gender budgeting remains important for governments worldwide. Gender budgeting not only signals a government's commitment to advancing gender equality, but it prompts more efficient resource use through the improved design of responsive fiscal policies. Countries in sub-Saharan Africa were some of the first adopters of gender budgeting, with Rwanda and Uganda continuing to demonstrate regional leadership. This chapter uses country self-assessment data from an IMF Gender Budgeting Survey to analyze the current state of gender budgeting practices in 34 sub-Saharan African countries. It examines strong practices across the regions and highlights areas for advancing practices.

INTRODUCTION

As the other chapters in this book illustrate, the COVID-19 pandemic intensified gender inequalities in sub-Saharan Africa, much as it did in the rest of the world, and it continues to hamper the region's growth potential (IMF 2021). The pandemic threatens progress toward addressing these inequalities. Although many governments provided immediate fiscal policy responses to support health sector spending needs and stabilize economies, the crisis hit the world's vulnerable population, especially women, particularly hard. In addition to women shouldering additional unpaid care work, sub-Saharan African women are more likely to work in the informal sector and outside of the reach of COVID-19 response measures. Meanwhile, many girls have left the school system permanently, and violence against women has increased (OECD 2020).

Well-structured fiscal policies supported by sound public financial management tools can potentially improve the conditions for women and men and advance government efforts toward greater gender equality—a practice known as gender budgeting. As defined in Alonso-Albarran and others (2021, 5) "gender budgeting incorporates a gender lens into the budget process to ensure that governments are aware of the impact of their choices on gender outcomes. Gender budgeting is not just about funding explicit gender equality initiatives. It also entails analyzing fiscal policies and budgetary decisions to understand their impact—intended and unintended—on gender equality and using this information to design and implement more effective policies." Originating in Australia in the 1980s, more than 100 countries now practice some elements of gender budgeting. Certain sub-Saharan African countries were early architects in developing gender budgeting (South Africa), while others have emerged over the years as regional leaders (Rwanda, Uganda). Some countries are recent adopters (Togo), and some have embarked on their first efforts (Sierra Leone).

This chapter provides an overview of gender budgeting practices in 34 sub-Saharan African countries using data obtained from an IMF survey completed by national officials.[1] This chapter focuses on the existence of gender budgeting practices in the region and not on their quality or effectiveness. It presents the status of gender budgeting in sub-Saharan African countries, as self-reported by government officials, and compares sub-Saharan African gender budgeting practices with countries in other regions. An examination of the challenges and key success factors sub-Saharan African countries have faced when implementing gender budgeting follows this analysis. The chapter concludes with a short summary and discusses next steps for the region.

STATUS OF GENDER BUDGETING IN SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA

Since the 1990s, gender budgeting initiatives have taken hold across sub-Saharan Africa. In 1995, South Africa launched its first Women's Budget Initiative, becoming one of the earliest adopters of gender budgeting internationally and inspiring the introduction of gender budgeting in countries across the region (Kolovich 2018). For some countries in the region, however, gender budgeting momentum has waxed and waned, including South Africa's. Many factors account for this waning, including changes in political support and limited capacity (Polzer, Nolte, and Seiwald 2021).

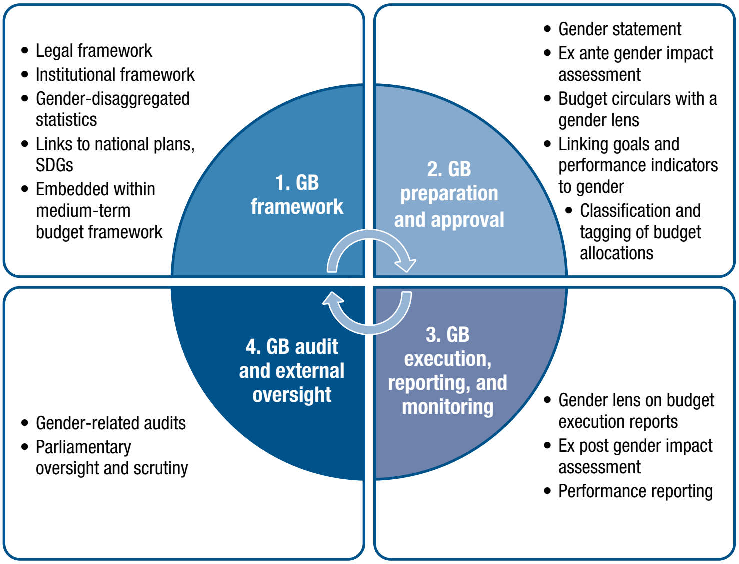
Today, some sub-Saharan African countries have more advanced gender budgeting practices, while others are just starting out. For example, Rwanda and Uganda have successfully embedded gender budgeting tools into existing budgeting procedures, and, as a result, gender budgeting has reputedly influenced changes in fiscal policies (Stotsky, Kolovich, and Kebhaj 2016). At the same time, many countries in the region, such as Togo, are making a strong start. Each of the 34 sub-Saharan African countries that responded to the IMF's survey have introduced at least one gender budgeting practice or tool. The IMF created the survey in 2018 and collected answers over 2019–21, with some additions and updates in 2023. Following the IMF's gender budgeting framework described in Box 16.1 and the concepts presented in the IMF's gender budgeting in the G20 working paper by Alonso-Albarran and others (2021), the 12 public financial management instruments covered by the IMF survey and their associated 23 questions used in this analysis examine and compare gender budgeting tools and practices across

[1] Government officials from 34 sub-Saharan African countries participated in the online self-assessment multiple-choice survey. Survey results are based on country declarations and are static in that they capture the existence of a practice or tool at a specific point in time (https://cvent.me/m950my).

Box 16.1. IMF Gender Budgeting Framework and Survey

The IMF applies a holistic approach to gender budgeting in which each phase of the budget cycle incorporates a gender perspective. Gender budgeting tools and practices support the integration of gender into the four phases, from budget planning and preparation to auditing and evaluation, as illustrated in Figure 16.1.1. This approach has evolved over time, beginning with a conceptual framework outlined in the IMF's assessment of gender-budgeting practices in G7 countries (IMF 2017) and further adapted in the gender budgeting in G20 Countries working paper (Alonso-Albarran and others 2021).

Figure 16.1.1. A Holistic Approach to Gender Budgeting throughout the Budget Cycle



Source: Alonso-Albarran and others 2021.
Note: GB = gender budgeting; SDGs = Sustainable Development Goals.

The IMF developed a gender budgeting survey based on this framework. The survey captures information on gender budgeting practices from countries globally and is the basis for this analysis. The survey was issued in 2018 with answers collected over 2019–23 and includes information on fiscal policies related to gender equality, the existence of gender budgeting practices and tools, and challenges as well as success factors.

Government officials from 34 sub-Saharan African countries participated in the online self-assessment multiple-choice survey. Survey results are based on country declarations and are static in that they capture the existence of a practice or tool at a specific point in time. However, it is worth noting that gender budgeting practices can vary over time, and what countries report one year may not necessarily be practiced to the same extent in the next. Additionally, although IMF staff have conducted a general validation process, actual practices may differ. Responses at the central government level provide the basis for this chapter.

TABLE 16.1.

Count of Gender Budgeting Practices in Sub-Saharan Africa		
1–8 Tools and Practices	**9–15 Tools and Practices**	**16+ Tools and Practices**
Botswana	Benin	Rwanda
Burundi	Burkina Faso	Tanzania
Central African Republic	Cameroon	Togo
Chad	Congo (Republic)	Zimbabwe
Comoros	Cote d'Ivoire	
Congo (Democratic Republic)	Ethiopia	
Gabon	The Gambia	
Lesotho	Kenya	
Malawi	Liberia	
Namibia	Madagascar	
São Tomé and Principe	Mauritius	
Seychelles	Mozambique	
Swaziland	Niger	
	Senegal	
	South Africa	
	Uganda	
	Zambia	

Source: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey.
Note: Country tools and practices are based on country declarations in the IMF gender budgeting survey and this figure reflects the existence of tools at a point in time and not their quality or effectiveness. The IMF created the survey in 2018, and answers were collected over 2019–21, with some updates in 2022.

sub-Saharan African countries. Annex 16.1 outlines the 12 instruments and corresponding questions about tools and practices (23 total).

The number of gender budgeting practices and tools applied across the region is considerable. Table 16.1 highlights the number of gender budgeting practices and tools that each sub-Saharan African country has declared to have adopted. Half of the countries surveyed reported they have 9 to 15 tools or practices, while four countries have 16 or more tools or practices. The latter are Rwanda, Tanzania, Zimbabwe, and Togo. Countries with the lowest tool count or practices are those with policies to promote gender equality but no additional gender budgeting practices, including Gabon and Comoros.

Sub-Saharan African countries have adopted a higher number of gender budgeting tools and practices in the first two phases or pillars of the budget cycle than in the last two. Table 16.2 outlines the 12 instruments under each of the four pillars of the IMF's gender budgeting framework and identifies which country has at least one tool or practice in place for each. Across the four pillars, sub-Saharan African countries are more likely to have gender budgeting practices in legal and institutional frameworks and budget preparation. Although sub-Saharan African countries have fewer practices in the downstream pillars, most countries have started to integrate gender budgeting considerations into parliamentary oversight.

The Legal and Institutional Framework for Gender Budgeting

Almost half of sub-Saharan African countries surveyed have laws or regulations that enshrine a gender perspective into the budget process. While many countries have included gender budgeting requirements in their regulations, only seven include requirements in an organic or a public finance law. For example, Uganda has included this requirement in the 2015 Public Financial Management Act. Enshrining gender budgeting into law is considered a good practice because it improves the likelihood that gender budgeting will continue over time and across political cycles (see also Chapter 14).

Nearly 80 percent of countries surveyed have some form of institutional framework in place for gender budgeting. Gender equality is an important issue for all ministries and departments. While the central budgetary authority leads and coordinates gender budgeting efforts, line departments and the ministry or agency for gender equality have play essential roles in developing sector strategies for gender equality and implementing programs. An institutional framework that outlines roles and responsibilities for gender budgeting is critical. For example, South Africa introduced in 2019–20 a Gender Responsive Planning, Budgeting, Monitoring, Evaluation and Auditing framework detailing how the government will incorporate gender mainstreaming into public finances. Similarly, Ethiopia's 2012 National Gender Responsive Budgeting Guidelines provide information on the national legal, policy, and institutional framework for gender equality and describe key steps for mainstreaming gender into the national budget cycle.

In most sub-Saharan African countries, the primary institution responsible for gender budgeting is the ministry of finance or the ministry or agency for gender equality. For example, the responsibility for gender budgeting reform in The Gambia is shared between the Ministry of Finance and Economic Affairs and the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Welfare, while in Ethiopia, the Ministry of Finance is the central entity in charge of steering gender budgeting reform; however, a Gender Affairs Directorate supports the gender responsiveness review of budget submissions during budget hearings. Some countries have taken a different approach. Senegal distributes the responsibility for gender budgeting more widely to include units within departments or agencies as well as an independent agency. For gender budgeting to be most effective, there must be strong leadership from the ministry of finance with support from a ministry or agency responsible for gender equality (Downes and Nicol 2020).

The majority of sub-Saharan African countries collect gender-disaggregated data. These data are necessary for understanding a country's gender inequalities and provide the foundation for many gender budgeting tools, for example, ex ante and ex post gender impact assessments. Applying gender-disaggregated data in the budget process varies widely. Some countries reported using the data occasionally or frequently to develop gender-related performance indicators and targets, to inform decision making on policies and new legislation, and to inform analyses on gender issues. Only half of the governments collecting these data publish the statistics.

A Gender Perspective in Budget Preparation

Each surveyed sub-Saharan African country has gender equality policies in place to respond to country-specific challenges. National or sectoral gender equality policies can help ensure adequate consideration of equality goals during budget planning and prioritization. In sub-Saharan Africa, a national development plan or individual sectorial or ministerial plans often integrate these policies, providing a foundation for gender budgeting practices. For example, Zimbabwe officially adopted gender budgeting in 2007 with the objective of achieving gender equality and inclusive growth in line with national commitments (Zimbabwe Ministry of Finance and Economic Development 2023). Translating policies into specific goals with measurable indicators is a good practice for measuring a country's progress toward closing gender equality gaps.

Nine sub-Saharan African countries have government-wide gender equality performance targets, while seven have sector-specific targets. Setting performance targets for gender equality goals and policies improves monitoring and tracking of a country's progress in key areas. For example, Rwanda has performance measures and targets in its National Strategy for Transformation I (NST I 2017–24). Scaling up Early Childhood Development Center services at the village level is one of these targets.

Over two-thirds of countries surveyed link gender equality goals to programs. Half of these countries also cost goals on an annual or medium-term basis. Linking gender equality goals with program objectives allows governments to track implementation of programs expected to advance gender equality and identify areas where more attention is needed. Simultaneously, costing programs linked to gender equality goals can help ensure proposals are prioritized within allocated expenditure ceilings. For example, Rwanda links costed subprograms, whenever applicable, to the achievement of the National Gender Policy and NST 1 (2017–24).

Only one-quarter of sub-Saharan African countries produce an annual gender budget statement; nevertheless, the countries that produce these statements are likely to publish them. A gender budget statement is a gender-specific policy and accountability document that a government crafts to show how the annual budget aims to improve gender equality. The statement takes stock of where a country stands with reaching gender equality goals, describes new budget proposals and previous actions expected to advance progress toward equality goals, and can include an analysis of aggregate spending on gender equality or beneficiaries. Publishing a gender budget statement is a good practice for improving accountability and receiving feedback on gender budgeting practices from civil society. Zimbabwe's Ministry of Finance and Economic Development leads gender budgeting and has recorded progress to date in published National Gender Budget Statements since 2022. This statement outlines gender-specific expenditures that the government will track along with budget implementation. Similarly, Togo has made considerable efforts toward implementing gender budgeting in recent years, including introducing gender budget statements (Box 16.2).

Just under half of surveyed sub-Saharan African countries issue guidelines for gender budgeting procedures in budget call circulars. Issuing detailed instructions in the budget circular not only signals that the government takes gender budgeting seriously but it also ensures that gender equality perspectives adequately inform budget submissions. These guidelines allow for a coordinated and comprehensive approach that improves efficiency during budget preparation and negotiation. Uganda has refined its budget circular instructions over time and adjusts them after each budget cycle. For example, after learning that sectors were providing blanket plans for addressing gender inequalities in their Budget Framework Papers, the Ministry of Finance made its budget circular instructions

Box 16.2. Case Study of a Recent Gender Budgeting Adopter: Togo

Togo has undertaken ambitious budget reforms in recent years. The government of Togo undertook flagship reform by transitioning from line-item to program budgeting in 2020, setting the stage to introduce gender budgeting. In 2023, the Togolese prepared their third Gender Budget Statement (GBS).

The process of introducing gender budgeting in Togo started in 2018. The government achieved results through a collaborative approach. A small group of gender focal points in line ministries reports to the Prime Minister and the Ministers of Finance, Women, and Planning. The authorities intend to formalize this structure by creating a gender budgeting unit within the Ministry of Finance, spearheading gender budgeting across government. Regular communication with the public has been key to gathering stakeholder support for the process and improving accountability for gender reforms.

A 2020 decree on the publication of budgetary documents paved the way for a GBS. Later that year, the authorities created a roadmap for gender budgeting, defining methodological, legal, and organizational aspects and gender budgeting tools. Key milestones in the roadmap included: (1) integrating the process in the budget calendar, (2) providing gender budgeting instructions and templates in the budget circular, (3) formulating budget allocations based on a gender impact assessment, and (4) publishing a GBS. Togo published its first GBS with the 2022 budget law, covering an initial group of six pilot ministries that had analyzed their budget programs using the OECD Development Assistance Committee (DAC) gender marking methodology. The GBS shows the results of this analysis and highlights how the budget contributes to the national gender equality policy.

At the outset of the 2022 budget process, the Prime Minister's budget call circular gave instructions to the ministries, with templates to assist them in identifying gender sensitive budget allocations. Budget negotiations and the discussions in Parliament involved the gender focal points in the ministries. Training for government officials and members of Parliament and a media campaign to inform the public preceded the presentation of the 2022 GBS. To monitor the budget execution of gender-related spending, disaggregated gender-related spending information will supplement quarterly and annual performance reports.

Togo is now rolling out gender budgeting to a wider group of line ministries. Challenges that lie ahead include the introduction of quality management processes, to ensure that the expanding number of line ministries consistently apply the gender marking method, and of in-depth ex ante gender impact assessments. These measures will help increase the budget impact in operationalizing the government's gender equality agenda.

Source: Togolese Republic, Ministry of Economy and Finance, Gender Responsive Budget Document (DBSG) 2022; DBSG 2023.

more specific the following year, requiring sectors to outline detailed actions in an annexed template (Stotsky, Kolovich, and Kebhaj 2016).

Eight sub-Saharan African countries conduct ex ante gender impact assessments on some or all new government policy initiatives. In some countries, individual spending ministries or departments (Mauritius and Tanzania) conduct these assessments, while in others, the ministry or agency responsible for gender equality conducts the assessments (Republic of Congo, Cote d'Ivoire, and Kenya). It is a good practice for the government official in the line ministry responsible for the program or policy to conduct the assessment early in the program or policy design. Of these countries, only four have a common gender impact assessment methodology—which is a good practice because it enables consistency and comparability across ministries and allows for streamlined quality checks. In some countries, the ministry or agency for gender equality has the sole responsibility for quality control of these assessments (Republic of Congo and Cote d'Ivoire), while other countries share responsibility with the ministry or agency for gender equality, ministry of finance, and gender units in line ministries (Tanzania and Zimbabwe). For these assessments to inform budget decisions, it is a good practice for the ministry of finance to conduct quality controls and integrate the assessment into budget negotiations or briefings.

Many sub-Saharan African countries report they classify their budgets according to programs, although their definition, usage, and effectiveness of programmatic classification can vary widely. In general, a programmatic budget structure could make it easier to integrate gender equality issues into budget decisions and allow for more effective tracking of expenditures that likely advance gender equality. In nearly all countries reporting they classify their budgets according to programs, the countries incorporate gender into either stand-alone gender programs (16 percent), other individual programs (37 percent), or both (47 percent).

Gender in Budget Execution and Monitoring

A third of sub-Saharan African countries report on the execution of gender-related expenditures. Monitoring and evaluating the implementation of gender-related programs or policies sheds light on whether funds achieve gender equality objectives while improving accountability and transparency. For an example of Rwanda's effective monitoring approach, see Box 16.3. Eight of the surveyed countries report on gender-related expenditures, while six compare approved with actual gender-related expenditures.

Only five sub-Saharan African countries perform ex post gender impact assessments of budget expenditures. Ex post gender impact assessments are a key tool for evaluating the effects of revenue and expenditure initiatives on gender equality. These assessment findings inform and improve the design of existing and new policies and programs. For example, the South Africa's Department of Trade and Industry's ex post analysis of expenditures to small, medium, and micro-enterprises observed that spending on these enterprises was a small percentage of the Department's budget despite women's overrepresentation as owners. This assessment resulted in the Department increasing allocations to support and promote women business owners (Stotsky, Kolovich, and Kebhaj 2016). Ex post gender impact assessments can also be used in reporting—for example, Burkina Faso uses these assessments in an annual report on the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals.

Audit and Parliamentary Oversight of Gender Budgeting

Parliamentary and legislative oversight of gender equality initiatives is a robust practice across sub-Saharan African countries. Over two thirds of sub-Saharan African countries' legislatures and parliaments are involved in gender equality issues—likely a result of nearly 60 percent of countries having established a designated committee for gender issues. For example, Namibia's Standing Committee on Gender Equality, Social Development and Family Affairs addresses gender issues

Box 16.3. Sub-Saharan African Success Story: Rwanda's Gender Monitoring Office

Rwanda has some of the most prominent gender budgeting practices in the region. In addition to a solid legal framework, clear focus on gender-disaggregated data collection, and extensive use of gender budget statements as a tool for integrating gender in the budget preparation, Rwanda has built a strong system of monitoring and evaluating results.

Rwanda established a Gender Monitoring Office (GMO) in 2007 with a mandate to ensure compliance and effective implementation of various national, regional, and international commitments, including on gender responsive budgeting. The GMO conducts field visits to monitor quality and conformity with gender budget statements and audits results that line ministries achieve. The GMO then produces an Annual Report that identifies achievements and existing challenges and supports planning for the next fiscal year (Gender Monitoring Office 2020).

For example, in its Annual Report 2019–2020, the GMO's assessment of FY2018/19 gender budget statements found positive results, including increased retention and performance of boys in school, improved health care for women, and increased access to clean water. The latter not only saved women quality time and households money, but women were also actively involved in water management committees. The report also highlighted areas for improvement, including that a wide gap in the gender distribution of employment, especially in leadership positions, remains in all districts audited. The GMO called for increased efforts from all levels to address this gap.

To further facilitate monitoring, Rwanda developed a gender management information system, which is a database for national gender targets and indicators that is expected to provide sex-disaggregated data wherever it is needed for gender responsive decision making, planning, and budgeting.

Source: Gender Monitoring Office, Government of Rwanda 2021. https://www.gmo.gov.rw.

across party lines and promotes gender equality to improve the status of women. Establishing a gender committee ensures that the legislature remains involved and can reinforce accountability on gender budgeting reforms. Across sub-Saharan Africa, the role of the legislature varies, with 32 percent discussing the budget impact on gender equality or conducting hearings on gender equality issues. Far fewer discuss the tax policy impact on gender equality (9 percent). For example, Ethiopia's Standing Committee for Women, Youth and Children of the Parliament makes recommendations to reinforce the effectiveness of the budget in the attainment of gender equality goals before legislative approval. Additionally, Uganda's Parliament has played a critical role in promoting and enforcing gender and equity budgeting. At the budget approval level, Parliament receives a Certificate of Gender and Equity Compliance when various budget products are satisfied. In this process, champions from the Uganda Women Parliamentary Association call on colleagues to critically vet Budget Framework Papers for gender and equity responsiveness.

National audit institutions are less involved in reviewing or assessing gender equality policies. Only five sub-Saharan African countries stated that the national auditor produced a report on the performance of gender programs or activities. Independent evaluations of gender programs and activities are essential for transparency and accountability, identifying implementation challenges, and incorporating

TABLE 16.2.

Sub-Saharan Africa Countries' Gender Budget Practices

	1. Legal and Institutional Framework			2. Budget Preparation					3. Budget Execution and Monitoring		4. Audit and Parliamentary Oversight	
	Legal Framework on Gender Budgeting	Institutional Framework	Fiscal Data Disaggregated by Gender	Gender Statements	Ex ante Gender Impact Assessments	Budget Circular Containing Specific Guidelines on Gender Objectives	Linking Gender Goals to Programs and Performance Indicators	Budget Classification Incorporates a Gender Perspective	Budget Execution Reports Incorporate Gender Perspective	Ex post Gender Impact Assessments	Gender Related Audits	Parliamentary Oversight
Benin	■	■	■		■		■	■	■	■		■
Botswana		■	■				■					
Burkina Faso	■	■	■	■		■	■	■		■		■
Burundi	■	■		■								■
Cameroon		■	■			■	■	■	■			■
Central African Republic												■
Chad		■				■	■					
Comoros												
Congo (Democratic Republic)			■									■
Congo (Republic)		■	■		■		■	■				■
Cote d'Ivoire		■	■		■		■	■			■	
Ethiopia	■	■	■	■		■	■	■	■			
Gabon												
Kenya	■	■		■	■	■	■	■				
Lesotho							■	■	■			■
Liberia	■	■	■	■		■	■	■				■
Madagascar	■	■	■	■			■		■			■
Malawi		■	■									■

Mauritius		■	■		■	■	■		■			■
Mozambique		■	■				■	■				
Namibia		■				■	■					■
Niger	■	■	■	■		■	■		■			
Rwanda	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■		■	■
São Tomé and Principe												■
Senegal		■	■	■		■	■	■				■
Seychelles			■				■	■				■
South Africa	■	■	■			■	■	■				■
Swaziland		■	■			■	■	■				
Tanzania	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■			
The Gambia		■					■	■	■			■
Togo	■	■	■	■		■	■	■	■	■		■
Uganda	■	■	■	■	■		■		■	■	■	■
Zambia	■	■	■				■	■	■		■	■
Zimbabwe	■	■	■		■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■

No Gender Budgeting Tool or Practice	At least one Gender Budgeting Tool or Practice
	■

Source: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey.

Note: This table outlines the 12 instruments under each of the four pillars of the IMF's gender budgeting framework and identifies which country has at least one tool or practice in place for each; see Annex 16.1 for a list of associated questions behind each instrument. If a country answered yes to any one of the associated questions, then the square was colored green. Note that for the indicator on "linking gender goals to programs and performance indicators," the green marking indicates countries that reported "yes" to questions 14 and/or 19 only (If gender equality goals are set, are they linked to programs? Are there performance targets related to gender equality?). This does not necessarily entail program-based budgeting. As a reminder, country tools and practices are based on country declarations in the IMF gender budgeting survey, and this figure reflects the self-reported existence of tools at a point in time, not their quality or effectiveness.

lessons learned to strengthen future policy designs. For example, Uganda's Supreme Audit Institution, with support from the International Organization of Supreme Audit Institutions' Development Initiative, conducts an audit of government efforts toward the elimination of intimate partner violence against women.

COMPARISON OF SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA'S GENDER BUDGETING PRACTICES WITH OTHER COUNTRIES

The level of gender budgeting practices of low-income and developing countries (LIDC) and emerging market economies (EME) within sub-Saharan Africa is similar to those outside the region. Beyond sub-Saharan Africa, the survey collected data on gender budgeting practices from 71 other countries worldwide, including 10 LIDCs and 49 EMEs. Figure 16.1 compares the average results for sub-Saharan African countries with other LIDCs and EMEs. The average Gender Budgeting Index[2] for sub-Saharan African countries is slightly above other LIDCs and EMEs, but both fall under the "basic" gender budgeting practice category. Consistent with the finding from Alonso-Albarran and others (2021), no country has reached an overall "advanced" practice level.

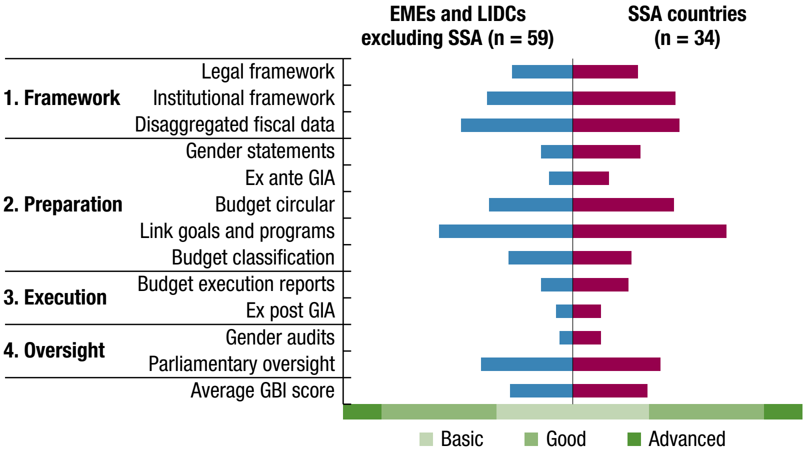
Observers note that LIDC and EMEs within and outside sub-Saharan African countries demonstrate good practices regarding institutional frameworks, disaggregated fiscal data collection, budget circular, linking goals and programs, and parliamentary oversight. Sub-Saharan African countries slightly outperform other LIDC and EMEs in select practices in budget preparation (gender statements, ex ante gender impact assessments, budget circular) and in budget execution reports and gender audits. Consistent with the findings of the G20 paper, the greatest weaknesses are in ex post and ex ante gender impact assessments and gender audits.

Sub-Saharan Africa is comparable with other regions in implementing gender budgeting. Figure 16.3 shows that most regions slightly outcompete the others in one or two areas but, broadly, all regions follow a similar pattern. For example, sub-Saharan African countries slightly outperform other regions regarding gender audits, budget execution reports, and linking goals and programs, although the first two are still at the basic practice level.

While advanced economies fare better in certain gender budgeting practices, they face similar challenges as LIDC and EME in many areas. Figure 16.2 shows that advanced economies outperform LIDC and EMEs in disaggregated fiscal data, gender statements, and ex ante gender impact assessments. However, these countries face similar challenges as LIDCs and EMEs regarding gender audits, and they score similarly or lower than LIDCs and EMEs in certain practices, specifically budget execution reports.

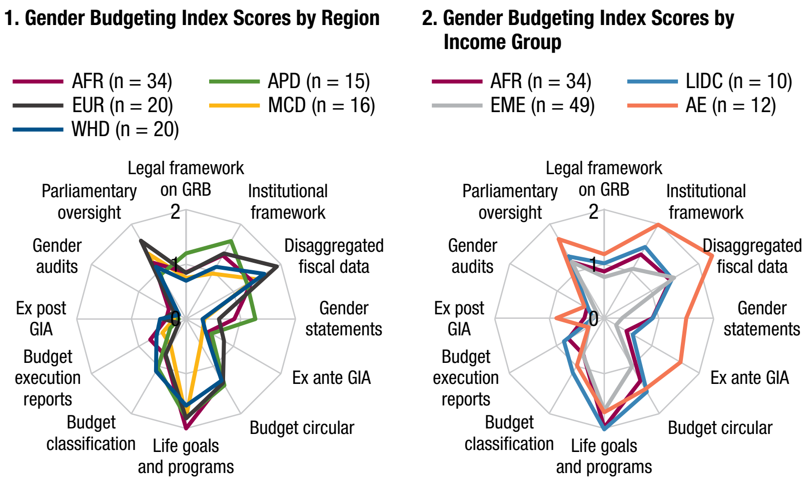
[2] The Gender Budgeting Index was introduced in the IMF's Gender Budgeting Practices in G20 Countries Working Paper by Alonso-Albarran and others (2021) and is an index calculated by assigning a score (from zero to three) to 23 key questions within the survey that relate to the 12 public financial management instruments used in a budget cycle. These are the same questions that were used to count practices in Table 16.2. For a list of the questions see Annex 16.1. The unweighted average of the 23 questions is equal to the overall country Gender Budgeting Index.

Figure 16.1. Public Financial Management Tools Used to Support Gender Budgeting Using the Average Scores of the Gender Budgeting Index



Sources: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey; and IMF staff.
Note: EMEs = emerging market economies; GBI = Gender Budgeting Index; GIA = gender impact assessments; LIDCs = low-income developing countries; SSA = sub-Saharan Africa. The bars are the average scores of the GBI of each country group. For a description of this index, see footnote 2.

Figure 16.2. Gender Budgeting Index Scores by Region and Income Group



Sources: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey; and IMF staff.
Note: Since the publication of the IMF's Gender Budgeting Practices in G20 Countries by Alonso-Albarran and others (2021), additional countries have been added to the IMF Gender Budgeting Database; specifically, eight countries have been added to the Western Hemisphere Department region and four to the African Department region. AE = advanced economy; AFR = Africa; APD = Asia and Pacific; EME = emerging market economies; EUR = Europe; GIA = gender impact assessments; GRB = gender-responsive budgeting; LIDC = low-income developing countries; MCD = Middle East and Central Asia; WHD = Western Hemisphere.

Development partner support is likely a key factor in the increase in gender budgeting practices across sub-Saharan Africa. The survey results for sub-Saharan African countries align with the literature highlighting that international organizations and financial and technical support by development partners to LIDCs culminated in greater gender budgeting adoption in these countries. Indeed, IMF technical assistance and supporting organizations' capacity initiatives to sub-Saharan African countries in this public financial management reform have increased over recent years.

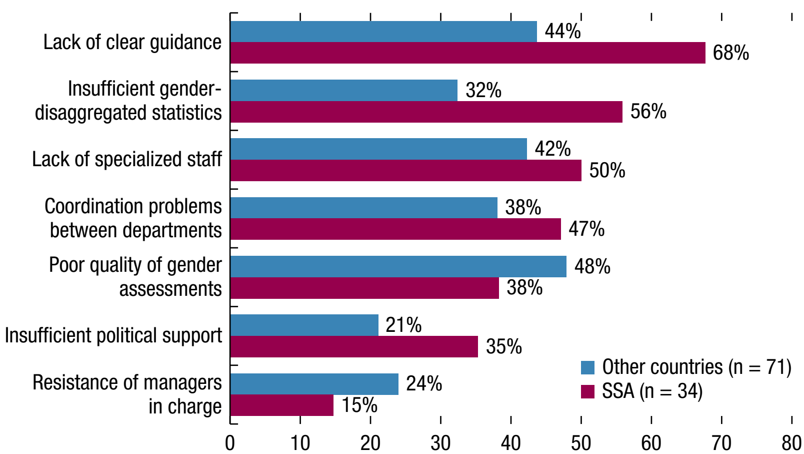
IMPLEMENTATION OF GENDER BUDGETING IN SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA—CHALLENGES AND SUCCESS FACTORS

Sub-Saharan African countries cite lack of clear guidance as the most pressing challenge when implementing gender budgeting. As outlined in Figure 16.3, 71 percent of sub-Saharan African countries' survey responses identified a lack of clear guidance on incorporating gender considerations into the annual budget as one of four major challenges when implementing gender budgeting. This factor is considerably higher than responses from all other countries. A cause of this challenge may be related to a lack of guidance provided in budget circulars. Indeed, less than half of surveyed sub-Saharan African countries include details on applying gender budgeting in a budget circular. Where these guidelines exist, they sometimes come from individual spending ministries to subordinate departments and, therefore, could be inconsistently applied or not enforced, compounding this challenge.

Other primary challenges identified in the region include insufficient gender-disaggregated statistics and coordination problems among departments. Despite nearly 70 percent of governments in the region collecting some disaggregated data,

Figure 16.3. Major Challenges Encountered when Successfully Implementing Gender Budgeting

(As a percentage of the sample)



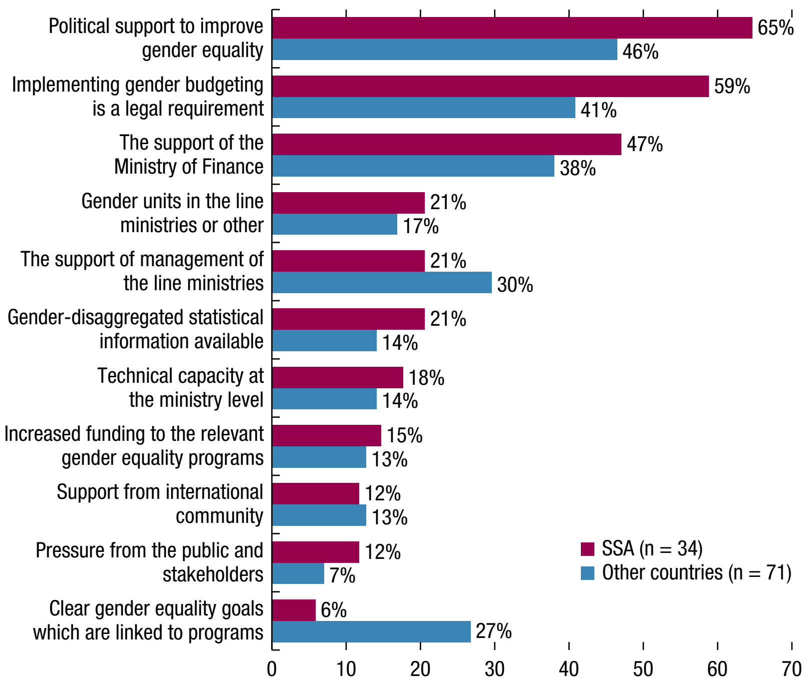
Source: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey.

sub-Saharan African countries have noted that insufficient gender-disaggregated statistical information inhibits them from adequately costing new gender initiatives. Additionally, challenges for roughly half of sub-Saharan African countries include a lack of specialized staff and coordination with departments with competencies in gender policies during budget preparation. Some countries have dedicated coordination units to overcome these challenges. For example, Uganda's Ministry of Gender established a national coordination mechanism to ensure systematic integration of gender equality and women's empowerment issues in development plans, policies, programs, and the budget. In Togo, a coordination mechanism between the budget directorate, the ministry of women, and gender focal points in line ministries ensures a consistent application of gender budgeting across public sector entities.

The top three success factors for implementing gender budgeting in sub-Saharan African countries align with the rest of survey respondents' answers—political support, binding legislative requirements, and support from the ministry of finance (Figure 16.4). A general understanding is that for gender budgeting to be successful, change needs to come alongside a high-level commitment. This finding is consistent with the literature highlighting that strong political

Figure 16.4. Most Important Factors for the Successful Implementation of Gender Budgeting

(As a percentage of the sample)



Source: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey.

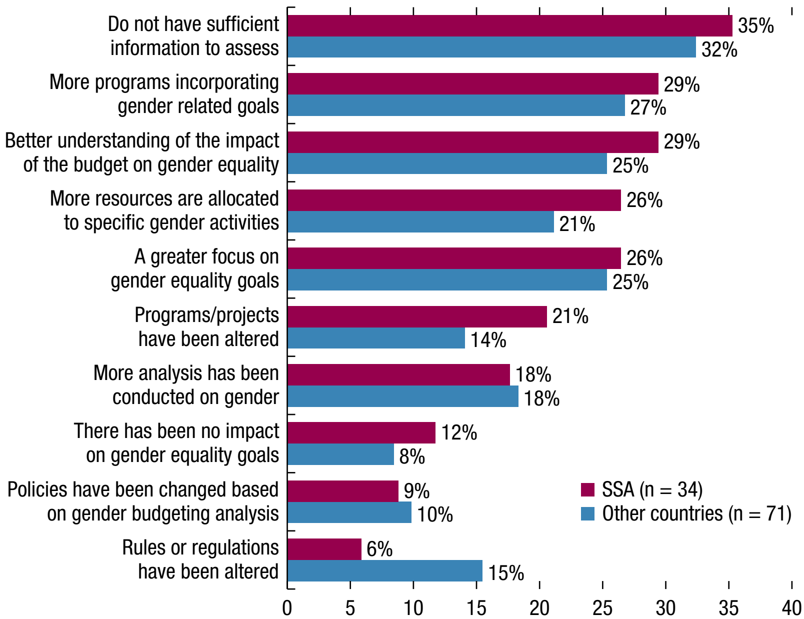
leadership, solid legal foundations, and clear direction from the ministry of finance add the necessary weight for gender budgeting reforms to take hold (for instance, OECD 2020; IMF 2017; Kolovich 2018).

THE IMPACT OF GENDER BUDGETING ON GENDER EQUALITY

Across sub-Saharan African countries, gender budgeting has primarily increased the number of programs that have gender-related goals, increased resources allocated to gender activities, and provided a better understanding of the budget impact on gender equality (Figure 16.5). The direct impact of implementing gender budgeting on gender equality is not easily measured. An increased awareness of gender equality goals may have brought to light key equality gaps and could have resulted in a redistribution of resources to address challenges. Additionally, gender budgeting has increased the understanding of the intended and unintended impact of the budget on either improving or undermining gender equality in sub-Saharan African countries, which could have led to modifying programs and projects during their development. Of note, rules or regulations seem to have been altered in other countries more frequently in response to gender budgeting than in sub-Saharan African countries.

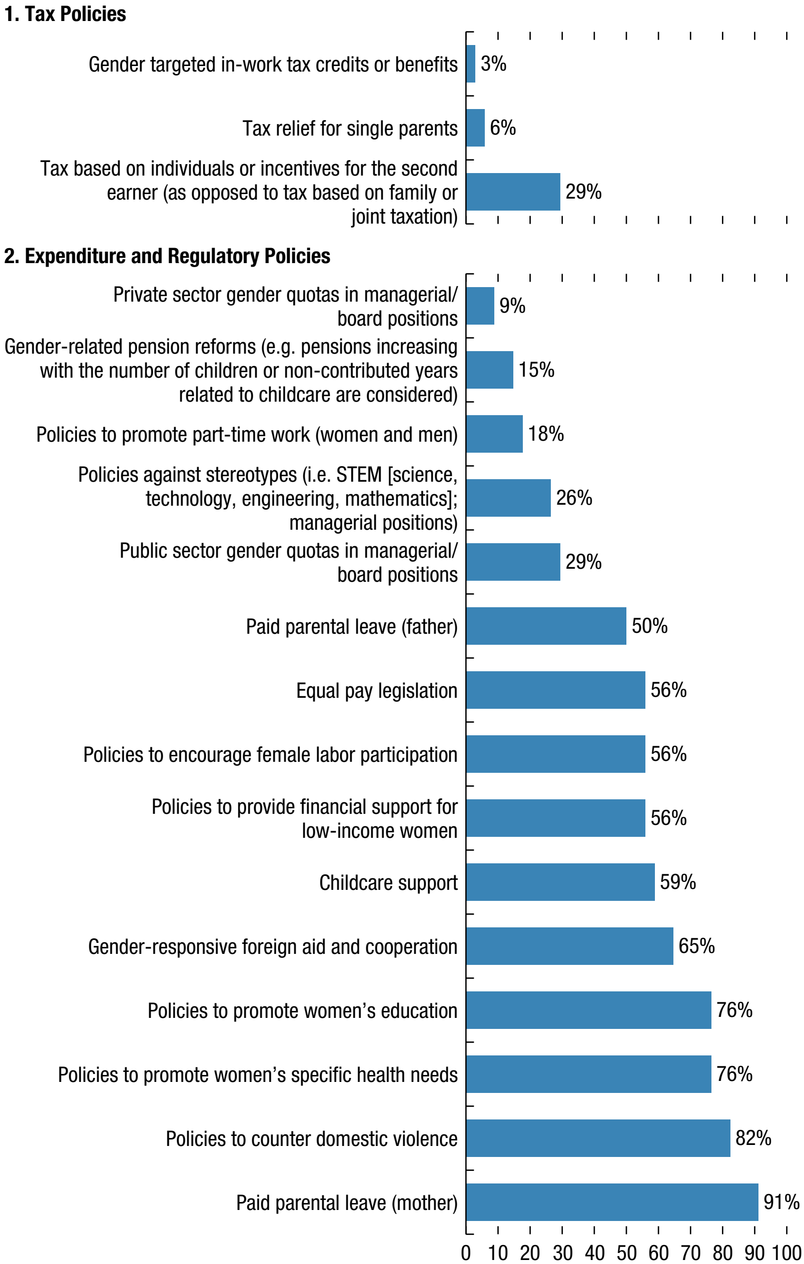
The introduction of gender-related fiscal policies has accompanied progress in gender budgeting implementation. Figure 16.6 shows that nearly all sub-Saharan African countries surveyed have introduced paid parental leave for mothers, a key

Figure 16.5. Impact of Gender Budgeting on Gender Equality
(As a percentage of the sample)



Source: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey.

Figure 16.6. Gender-Related Fiscal Policies Introduced by Sub-Saharan African Countries
(As a percent of the sample)



Source: IMF Gender Budgeting Survey.
Note: This illustration is based on a list of common fiscal policies that intend to promote gender equality, and it is not intended to be an exhaustive list.

determinant for women's continued labor force participation. Additionally, policies to counter domestic violence, promote women's specific health needs, and increase access to education for girls are among the top fiscal policies in place across the region. While over 50 percent of countries in sub-Saharan Africa have introduced at least 10 specific gender-related expenditure or regulatory policies, tax policies have been less widely adopted. The tax policy lag is consistent with findings that gender budgeting has typically focused on expenditures and overlooked taxes (Kolovich 2018).

CONCLUSION

The budget is a core policy instrument of the government; integrating gender equality objectives will ultimately result in better budgetary decisions. Although gender budgeting reforms require significant effort, consistent incremental steps to implementation over the medium term with feedback loops for learning and improvement can help ensure this reform's success. That is, countries should not be afraid to get started.

Sub-Saharan African countries have made substantial progress in adopting and implementing gender budgeting practices over the past decades. Good practices involve gender budgeting frameworks, linking gender equality goals with programs, and parliamentary oversight. Given the status of gender budgeting in sub-Saharan Africa, developing and publishing gender budget statements and improving guidance in budget call circulars is a suggested way forward. Only one quarter of sub-Saharan African countries surveyed produce an annual gender budget statement. As a strategic document, a gender budget statement tracks progress made toward gender equality objectives and identifies the programs or policies in place to close equality gaps. These statements, therefore, not only increase accountability, they also improve annual budget prioritization and planning. Sub-Saharan African countries are readily able to develop these statements since the information to formulate a statement has already been collected in many cases. That is, each country surveyed has gender equality policies in place and over two thirds of surveyed countries stated that they link gender equality goals to programs.

Sub-Saharan African countries should ensure their budget call circular is specific to overcome the lack of clear guidance on incorporating gender considerations into the annual budget. A budget call circular should explain to line departments and agencies what is required of them during the budget cycle, provide details on meeting the requirements, and include any gender budgeting templates to submit with their budget submissions. To complement these instructions, training on requirements for government officials regarding gender budgeting should be incorporated into broader budget training. Less than half of sub-Saharan African countries surveyed issued guidelines for gender budgeting procedures in a budget call circular. Issuing guidelines can begin with the ministry of finance having a clear plan for gender budgeting, which, if improved, could result in a more efficient budget process.

ANNEX 16.1

ANNEX TABLE 16.1.1

Instruments and Corresponding IMF Gender Budgeting Survey Questions

12 "Instruments" or "Pillars"			23 Questions
1	Legal framework on GRB	Q9	Is there a legal provision for gender budgeting? (select all that apply)
2	Institutional framework	Q7	Does the government have a gender budgeting framework?
		Q10	Is there a specific institution with primary responsibility for gender budgeting reform? (select up to two responses)
		Q13	Is there a specific organization that coordinates discussions on gender issues during budget preparation?
3	Gender statements	Q15	Does the government produce and publish a gender budgeting statement?
4	Ex ante gender impact assessment to assess the impact of proposed policies on gender equality	Q17a	Does the government conduct ex ante gender impact assessments on new government policy initiatives?
		Q17c	Is there a common methodology for ex ante gender impact assessments?
		Q17d	How are gender impact assessments used in the budget preparation? (Example of response option: It is used to identify the budget lines with gender impact (quantitative or qualitative)
5	Budget circular containing specific guidelines on gender objectives	Q16a	Does the budget circular or guidelines include details on the application of gender budgeting? (select all that apply)
6	Linking gender goals to programs and performance indicators	Q2	Does the government have policies to promote gender equality? (select all that apply—response example: Yes, gender equality policies are part of the national development / strategic plan)
		Q14	If gender equality goals are set are they linked to programs?
		Q19	Are there performance targets related to gender equality?
7	Budget classification incorporates a gender perspective	Q21b	If yes, how is gender incorporated into the program classification? (21a: Is the budget classified according to programs?)
		Q22	Are budgetary allocations tagged with any type of budget classifiers to identify their linkage to gender objectives?
8	Fiscal data disaggregated by gender	Q25a	Does the government collect data disaggregated by gender?
		Q25b	Is this data published?
		Q25c	Indicate how often the data is used in decision making (multiple responses "inform budget decision making," "inform decision making on policies," "inform decision making on new legislation," and then options from Very Frequently, Frequently, Occasionally, Rarely, Never)
9	Budget execution reports incorporate gender perspective	Q26	Do budget execution reports issued by the government in-year include information on gender related expenditures?
		Q27	Does the government's end of year annual financial statement include information on the following?
10	Ex post gender impact assessments to assess the impact of policies on gender goals	Q28	Does the government conduct ex post gender impact assessments of budget expenditures?
		Q29 *adjusted to 28	Indicate how often the gender impact assessments (ex ante and ex post) have influenced decision making in the following areas (list of areas such as informed annual budget decision making, and options from Very Frequently, Frequently, Occasionally, Rarely, Never)
11	Gender-related audits	Q32	Has the National/Supreme audit institution in the past three years produced gender-related audit reports?
12	Parliamentary oversight	Q31	Has the legislature/Parliament in the last three years undertaken any of the following activities in relation to gender equality?

Source: Alonso-Albarran and others 2021.

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